

History from Zero - The Foundation Track

Chapter F5.1 — From Zero: How the RT Actually Tests History, the Sources, Prehistory and the Indus Valley Civilisation

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NOTE · HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

The opening chapter of the Foundation history track, and it does two jobs. First it settles METHOD, because history is the module where a beginner most easily spends fifty hours and gains four marks. The 2023 paper gives an unambiguous instruction: nine of its ten history questions were ancient, medieval or art-and-culture, and every one was answerable by RECOGNITION rather than recall - naming a site, matching a monument to a dynasty, placing a text with its author. Session 1 works out what that implies, and hands you a five-slot template and a stopping rule that make an unbounded subject bounded. The chapter then teaches from zero the material supplying the largest single share of those recognition questions: where knowledge of ancient India comes from (inscriptions, coins, texts, foreign accounts), the Stone Age and Chalcolithic sequence that ends in the first cities, and the Indus Valley Civilisation in full - discovery, chronology, extent, the sites and what each is famous for, town planning, economy, seals and script, religion, art, and the competing explanations of its decline. Study time 3 hours 30 minutes.

This is the FOUNDATION layer. Dates for ancient India are conventional and approximate; where two chronologies are in common textbook use, BOTH are printed rather than one being presented as settled. Archaeological attributions of individual finds to sites are stated as they appear in standard reference works. Claims that remain genuinely contested - the horse at Surkotada, the earliest rice at Koldihwa, the reading of the Harappan script, the identification of the Pashupati figure, and the cause of Harappan decline - are marked as contested rather than resolved, because a "not correct" question is often built on exactly the over-confident version.

Table of Contents

0. Why This Chapter Comes First, and Why It Is Half Method	3
1. Session 1 - How the RT Tests History, and How to Study It ★★★★★	4
1.1 The five-slot template, and the stopping rule	4
2. Session 2 - Where Our Knowledge Comes From, and Prehistory ★★★★★☆	6
2.1 The literary and foreign sources worth recognising	6
2.2 Prehistory - the Stone Age and Chalcolithic sequence	7
3. Session 3 - The Harappans I: Discovery, Extent, Sites, Cities ★★★★★	9
3.1 Extent - the four boundary sites	9
3.2 The sites - name paired with what it is famous for	10
4. Session 4 - The Harappans II: Economy, Script, Religion, Decline ★★★★★	13
4.1 The seals and the script	14
4.2 Decline - four theories, none decisive	15
5. Graded Practice - 42 Questions ★★★★★	17
5.1 Level 1 - Recognition	17
5.2 Level 2 - Understanding	18
5.3 Level 3 - Recruitment Test standard	19
6. Answers and Explanations	20
6.1 Level 1 - answers	20
6.2 Level 2 - answers	21
6.3 Level 3 - answers	22
7. One-Minute Revision	24
8. Five-Minute Wall Sheet	26

0. Why This Chapter Comes First, and Why It Is Half Method

History is the module where effort and marks come apart most violently. Getting the method right is worth more than any twenty facts.

WHY THIS EXISTS · THE PROBLEM THIS CHAPTER SOLVES

You have told me history is one of your three weak subjects. That is the normal position for an engineer and a banker, and it is not the difficulty here. **The difficulty is that history is unbounded.** Polity has a Constitution with 395 original Articles - a finite object. Labour law has 29 central statutes consolidated into four Codes - a finite object. **History has five thousand years and no edge.** A candidate who starts reading history without a stopping rule will still be reading it in March.

So this chapter refuses to open with facts. Session 1 establishes four things instead: **what the paper actually asked**; the difference between **recognition and recall**, which is the most useful distinction in this module; a **stopping rule**, so you know when a topic is finished; and a **revision mechanism**, because forgetting is the real enemy here, not difficulty.

Only then does it teach content - and the content it teaches first sits at the exact centre of what the paper rewards.

PYQ CONNECTION · THE EVIDENCE: WHAT THE 2023 PAPER DID WITH ITS TEN HISTORY QUESTIONS

From the full 120-question classification of [pyq/apfc2023_prepp.pdf](#), history and culture supplied **10 questions**. Their internal split is the finding:

- 1 **Nine** were **ancient, medieval, or art and culture**
- 2 **One** came from the freedom movement and modern India
- 3 **Zero** required a date to be produced from memory without a prompt
- 4 **Every one** presented the answer among four options, so partial knowledge scored

The 2015 paper gave history **9** questions; the 2025 paper (candidate-feedback estimate only) was closer to **half modern**. So the honest position: **ancient, medieval and cultural India is where the weight has demonstrably been, and modern India cannot be abandoned, because one paper in three leaned modern.** This module covers both and front-loads the ancient and cultural material.

The comparison that should decide your plan. Ten marks sit here at a very low cost per mark, because recognition questions can be answered from one exposure to a well-organised list. **History is cheap marks for a prepared candidate and near-zero for an unprepared one. There is no middle.**

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F5.1 - THE FOUR SESSIONS

- 1 **Session 1 - Method:** recognition versus recall, the five-slot template, the stopping rule (Section 1)
- 2 **Session 2 - Sources and prehistory:** how we know anything, and the Stone Age to Chalcolithic sequence (Section 2)
- 3 **Session 3 - The Harappans I:** discovery, chronology, extent, the sites, town planning (Section 3)
- 4 **Session 4 - The Harappans II:** economy, trade, seals and script, religion, art, decline (Section 4)

Then **42 graded questions**. Budget **four sessions**, about **a day and a half**. Session 1 is short and you should not skip it - it is what stops this module eating your March. **The Vedic Age follows immediately in F5.2.**

1. Session 1 - How the RT Tests History, and How to Study It ★★★★★

The paper does not ask you to explain history. It asks you to identify things. Only one of those is worth your time.

START FROM ZERO · RECOGNITION AND RECALL - THE DISTINCTION THAT RUNS THE WHOLE MODULE

RECALL means producing a fact from nothing. *In which year was Harappa first excavated?* You either have 1921 or you do not.

RECOGNITION means picking the fact out of a set. *Harappa was excavated in 1921 by (a) R. D. Banerji (b) Daya Ram Sahni (c) John Marshall (d) B. B. Lal.* Here you do not need the fact fully formed - you need enough of a trace to eliminate. If you know Banerji attaches to **Mohenjo-daro** and Marshall was the **Director-General who named the civilisation**, you are down to one plausible option without ever having memorised the sentence.

A four-option objective paper only ever tests recognition. That changes what "knowing a topic" means:

- 1 You do **not** need to write about Harappan town planning. You need to recognise **grid layout, citadel and lower town, burnt brick, covered drains** as Harappan when they appear in an option
- 2 You **do** need breadth, because recognition fails completely on material you have never once seen

The operational consequence, and it is the whole strategy of this module: in history, ONE careful exposure to a wide field beats FIVE exposures to a narrow one. In Polity the opposite holds, because those questions turn on precise distinctions between provisions you must carry exactly. **Do not bring your Polity habits here.** Coverage is the asset.

FROM YOUR OWN WORLD · WHY THIS IS A CREDIT-APPRAISAL PROBLEM, NOT A MEMORISATION PROBLEM

You appraise credit for a living, so you already own the reasoning.

When a proposal lands on your desk you do not read every page with equal attention. You know which four or five items decide the outcome - promoter track record, debt-service coverage, security cover, end-use. **You hold a mental template of what matters, built from many exposures, and you scan against it rather than reading afresh.** A junior officer without the template reads all ninety pages and still misses the problem.

History for the RT is exactly that. The template is: *for any period - which sites, which rulers, which texts, which monuments, which distinctive material feature.* Five slots, and every period fills those and nothing more.

And the template works because you have seen many files, not because you memorised one deeply. Exposure count across cases, not depth within a case - the reverse of what most candidates do with history.

1.1 The five-slot template, and the stopping rule

Every period is read against the same five slots. When all five are filled the period is **finished**, and you move on rather than deepening. That is the stopping rule, and it is what bounds an unbounded subject.

Slot	What goes in it, and what does NOT
Sites	The places. For prehistory and the Harappans this is most of the marks - a site name paired with the one thing it is famous for. Do NOT learn excavation reports; learn the pairing

Slot	What goes in it, and what does NOT
Rulers	Dynasties in sequence, with the two or three names actually tested. Do NOT learn regnal years; learn who preceded whom, because chronological-order questions are a standard RT format
Texts	Title paired with author or period, plus one line on what kind of book it is. Do NOT read the texts. Naming the author of the Arthashastra scores exactly what a week on it would
Monuments	Building or art object paired with its dynasty and style. The highest-yield slot in the module , and F5.5 is devoted to it
Distinctive feature	The one material marker separating this period from the previous one - a metal, a pottery type, a script, a burial practice. This is what statement-based questions turn on

The five slots to fill for every period, and nothing beyond them

Why the fifth slot earns its place. The harder questions rarely ask "when" or "who". They take the form *which of the following is characteristic of X*, and the answer is a material marker. **Covered drains mean Harappan. Microliths mean Mesolithic. Copper with stone means Chalcolithic.**

HIGH YIELD · THE THREE QUESTION FORMATS TO DRILL AGAINST, AND THE SCORING INSIGHT

- 1 **Straight identification** - *Mohenjo-daro is situated on the bank of the river ...* One fact, four options, no reasoning
- 2 **Matching (List-I with List-II)** - usually a site with a find, or a text with an author. **You do not need all four pairs.** Two confident pairs normally eliminate three of the four codes, and standard RT code sets are built so this works
- 3 **Statement-based / "not correct"** - the format that punishes vague familiarity, because three true statements all look plausible. It is also the format where knowing **why the wrong options are wrong** is the only thing that helps, which is why every answer in Section 7 gives that

On chronological-order questions. They look intimidating and are usually easy, because only relative order is needed. **Anchor on four fixed points - the Harappan cities, the Buddha, Ashoka, the Guptas - and place everything relative to them.** Almost any ancient-India ordering question falls to those four anchors alone.

MEMORY TECHNIQUE · THE REVISION MECHANISM - FORGETTING IS THE ENEMY, NOT DIFFICULTY

You will understand this chapter on first reading and will have lost about half of it in three weeks. That is normal for list-shaped material.

- 1 **Read the chapter once, properly**, attempting the check boxes honestly
- 2 **Then never re-read it.** Re-reading is the least efficient revision there is
- 3 **Revise from the Five-Minute Wall Sheet only** - Section 9 of every chapter, built to be the chapter compressed to what recognition needs
- 4 **Wall sheet at day 1, day 7, day 30.** Three five-minute passes beat one two-hour re-read, by a wide margin, for exactly this material
- 5 **Test, do not review.** Cover the sheet and say the pairings aloud before looking. Retrieval builds the trace; reading builds only familiarity

With three months to the RT, plan the passes now. Every Module 5 chapter adds one wall sheet to a stack you will run in about forty minutes in the final week, and **that forty-minute stack is the actual deliverable of this module** - the chapters are only the means of building it.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 1

- 1 State the 2023 history split and what it implies about ancient versus modern weight
- 2 Define recognition and recall, and say why only one is ever tested
- 3 Why does one exposure to a wide field beat five to a narrow one, in this module specifically?
- 4 Name the five slots and the stopping rule they give you
- 5 Name the three question formats, and the scoring insight for matching questions
- 6 Name the four chronological anchors for ancient India
- 7 State the revision schedule, and why retrieval beats re-reading

2. Session 2 - Where Our Knowledge Comes From, and Prehistory ★★★★★☆

Before the periods, the evidence. A surprising number of questions ask not what happened but how we know it.

START FROM ZERO · TWO FAMILIES OF SOURCE, AND WHY THE DISTINCTION IS EXAMINABLE

ARCHAEOLOGICAL sources - physical remains. Three sub-types, and the names themselves are asked:

- 1 **Epigraphy** - the study of **inscriptions**. The most reliable source available, because contemporary with the event and, cut in stone or metal, beyond later editing
- 2 **Numismatics** - the study of **coins**. Coins date layers, show a kingdom's extent, name rulers no text mentions, and carry titles and portraits
- 3 **Archaeology proper** - excavated settlements, pottery, tools, burials, monuments

LITERARY sources - written texts. Also three: **religious** literature (the Vedas and their descendants, the Buddhist and Jain canons); **secular** literature (statecraft, drama, chronicle); and **foreign accounts**, valuable precisely because a visitor notices what an insider never bothers to record.

Why this earns space in a Foundation chapter. Texts were copied by hand for centuries and can be interpolated, altered and re-dated; they also usually record what the powerful wished recorded. **An inscription cannot be revised after the fact.** So where text and inscription disagree, the inscription normally wins - and that principle is itself the answer to a family of questions about source reliability.

2.1 The literary and foreign sources worth recognising

Source	Author or origin	What it is, in one line
Arthashastra	Kautilya (Chanakya)	Treatise on statecraft and administration, associated with the Mauryan period
Indica	Megasthenes	Account of Mauryan India by the Seleucid ambassador at Chandragupta Maurya's court; survives only in fragments quoted by later writers
Mudrarakshasa	Vishakhadatta	Sanskrit play on Chandragupta Maurya's rise; a literary, not documentary, source
Rajatarangini	Kalhana (12th century)	Chronicle of the kings of Kashmir; often called India's first work of something close to historical writing
Ashtadhyayi	Panini	Sanskrit grammar; incidentally a source for the geography and society of its own time

Source	Author or origin	What it is, in one line
Mahabhashya	Patanjali	Commentary on Panini; a source for the post-Mauryan period
Fa-Hien's account	Fa-Hien , Chinese pilgrim	Visited during Chandragupta II ; describes a peaceful, lightly policed society
Si-yu-ki	Hiuen Tsang , Chinese pilgrim	Visited during Harshavardhana ; the fullest foreign description of 7th-century India, including Nalanda
Kitab-ul-Hind	Al-Biruni	11th-century Arabic account of Indian sciences, religion and society; came with Mahmud of Ghazni
Periplus of the Erythraean Sea	Anonymous Greek	Sailor's handbook of Indian Ocean ports and trade goods; the key source for Indo-Roman trade

Texts and foreign accounts: the pairings the paper uses

COMMON UPSC TRAP · THE PILGRIM-AND-PATRON PAIRS THAT GET CONFUSED, AND THE MAN WHO UNLOCKED THE INSCRIPTIONS

The pilgrim pairs are the most reliably tested set in the sources topic, and candidates lose them by mixing the pairs.

- 1 **Fa-Hien** with **Chandragupta II** (Gupta period)
- 2 **Hiuen Tsang** with **Harshavardhana** (7th century)
- 3 **Al-Biruni** with **Mahmud of Ghazni** (11th century)
- 4 **Megasthenes** with **Chandragupta Maurya** (Mauryan)

One line holds the three later ones apart: F before H before A, and the patrons follow the same order in time - Gupta, then Harsha, then Ghazni. The alphabet does the chronology for you. A fourth Chinese name, **I-tsing**, appears as a distractor; the patron in the stem is what separates them.

The decipherment, and it is the hinge of the whole subject. Ashoka's inscriptions stood unread for two thousand years because the **Brahmi** script had been forgotten. **James Prinsep deciphered Brahmi in 1837**, and with that the Mauryan period became historical rather than legendary - **before Prinsep nobody knew that the "Devanampiya Piyadasi" of the edicts was Ashoka.** The edicts use **Brahmi** (the great majority, left to right), **Kharosthi** (the north-west, right to left, derived from Aramaic), and **Greek and Aramaic** in present-day Afghanistan, where a bilingual edict was found at Kandahar.

And three facts that cover most numismatics questions: the earliest Indian coins are the **punch-marked** silver and copper pieces, also called **karshapana**, belonging to the sixth century BCE onwards; **the Indo-Greeks issued the first coins in India carrying a portrait and the king's name**, which is why their chronology is better established than that of contemporary Indian dynasties; and **the Guptas issued the largest number of gold coins** of any ancient Indian dynasty.

2.2 Prehistory - the Stone Age and Chalcolithic sequence

Why prehistory is here at all. It is recognition material of the cheapest kind - a site, a state, one distinguishing find - and it supplies the vocabulary that later questions assume. **Read the table once and revise it from the wall sheet; do not study it twice.**

Period	Rough date	Sites, and the one thing each is known for
Palaeolithic	Up to c. 10,000 BCE	Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh) - rock paintings , a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Pallavaram near Chennai - where Robert Bruce Foote found the first Palaeolithic tool recognised in India, in 1863 . Also Hunsgi, Didwana, the Belan and Soan valleys. Hunting and gathering; large quartzite hand-axes and cleavers; no pottery

Period	Rough date	Sites, and the one thing each is known for
Mesolithic	c. 10,000 to 6,000 BCE	Bagor (Rajasthan) - the largest Mesolithic site in India. Adamgarh (Madhya Pradesh) - with Bagor, the earliest evidence of animal domestication . Distinctive feature: microliths , very small stone tools set into handles. The earliest human burials in India are Mesolithic
Neolithic	c. 7,000 to 1,000 BCE, varying sharply by region	Mehrgarh (Baluchistan) - earliest farming settlement in the subcontinent, and earliest evidence of cotton , wheat and barley. Burzahom (Kashmir) - pit dwellings , and dogs buried with their masters . Chirand (Bihar) - bone tools . Koldihwa and Mahagara (Uttar Pradesh) - claimed earliest rice , a date that remains contested. Daojali Hading (Assam). Southern group Maski, Brahmagiri, Piklihal, Hallur - with ash mounds
Chalcolithic	c. 3,000 to 1,000 BCE, overlapping the Harappan	First use of metal - copper - alongside stone. Cultures named from type-sites: Ahar-Banas (Rajasthan), Kayatha and Malwa including Navdatoli, Jorwe (Maharashtra) with Inamgaon, Daimabad, Nevasa, Chandoli . Distinctive pottery Black-and-Red Ware . Daimabad yielded the famous bronze chariot and animal figures

The Stone Age and Chalcolithic sequence: dates approximate and conventional

HIGH YIELD · THE FOUR PREHISTORY ITEMS ACTUALLY ASKED, AND THE TRANSITION THAT MATTERS

- 1 **Bhimbetka = rock paintings**. The most reliably asked prehistory fact in the field
- 2 **Mehrgarh = earliest farming, earliest cotton**. In present-day Baluchistan, on the same cultural trajectory that ends in the Harappan cities
- 3 **Burzahom = pit dwellings and dog burials**. In Kashmir; the pairing is odd enough to stick
- 4 **Microliths = Mesolithic**, and **copper = Chalcolithic**. The two distinctive-feature pairings from this whole stretch

And the transition that makes prehistory matter rather than merely precede. Neolithic farming produced, for the first time, a **surplus** - more food than the producers ate. A surplus permits people who do not farm: potters, metalworkers, priests, administrators, soldiers. **Cities, writing and the state are all consequences of an agricultural surplus, and that is the causal chain running from Mehrgarh to Mohenjo-daro.** Hold the chain and the next two sessions stop being a list of sites and become the outcome of something.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 2

- 1 Name the two families of source and the three sub-types within each
- 2 Define epigraphy and numismatics, and say why an inscription usually outranks a text
- 3 Pair the four travellers with their patrons, in chronological order
- 4 Who deciphered Brahmi, in what year, and why does it matter so much?
- 5 Name the scripts used in Ashoka's inscriptions and where each was used
- 6 Give the site paired with rock paintings, with earliest farming, with pit dwellings
- 7 What tool defines the Mesolithic, and what metal the Chalcolithic?
- 8 State the causal chain from agricultural surplus to the state

3. Session 3 - The Harappans I: Discovery, Extent, Sites, Cities ★★★★★

India's first cities, built to a plan, drained better than most Indian towns were in 1900, and run by a state whose name we do not know.

START FROM ZERO · WHAT 'CIVILISATION' MEANS HERE, AND WHY THE HARAPPANS QUALIFY

In archaeology the word has a working test. A civilisation shows **cities** whose inhabitants are not all food producers; a **surplus economy with specialised crafts**; **writing**, even if unread; **monumental construction**; and **standardisation** of weights, measures and bricks, which implies an authority able to enforce it.

The Harappans satisfy all five, and the fifth is their signature. Bricks in the same **4:2:1** ratio across a territory a thousand kilometres wide; weights in one system from the Arabian Sea to the upper Ganga plain. **That degree of standardisation over that distance, without a single royal inscription, palace or identified temple, is the central puzzle of the civilisation** - it is plainly a state, and we cannot say what kind.

Two names, one thing. **Indus Valley Civilisation** after the river system where it was first found; **Harappan Civilisation** after the first site excavated. **Archaeologists prefer Harappan**, because Lothal, Dholavira, Rakhigarhi and Kalibangan are nowhere near the Indus. Both are correct and the paper uses both.

MUST MASTER · DISCOVERY AND CHRONOLOGY - THE FACTS THAT OPEN EVERY QUESTION SET

- 1 **Harappa** was excavated in **1921** by **Daya Ram Sahni**
- 2 **Mohenjo-daro** was excavated in **1922** by **R. D. Banerji**
- 3 Both worked under **Sir John Marshall**, then **Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India**, who announced the discovery and **gave the civilisation its name**
- 4 **Mohenjo-daro** means, in Sindhi, something close to "**mound of the dead**"

Chronology - and you must know that two conventions are in circulation:

- 1 **Current convention**, from radiocarbon dating: **Early Harappan c. 3300-2600 BCE, Mature Harappan c. 2600-1900 BCE, Late Harappan c. 1900-1300 BCE**
- 2 **Older textbook convention**, still printed in guides and still appearing in option sets: **c. 2500-1750 BCE** for the main phase

Do not treat either as wrong in the hall - answer with whichever the options offer. **The formulation safe on both, and the one to give in an interview, is "the mature phase falls in the second half of the third millennium BCE".**

One more placing fact. The Harappans are contemporary with **Mesopotamia** and with Egypt's Old and Middle Kingdoms, and theirs is a **Bronze Age** civilisation - copper and bronze, **no iron**. Iron reaches India centuries later, in the later Vedic period. **"The Harappans used iron" is therefore a standard false statement in a "not correct" question.**

3.1 Extent - the four boundary sites

The civilisation covered roughly **1.3 million square kilometres**, making it **the largest in area of the Bronze Age civilisations** - greater in extent than Egypt and Mesopotamia together. The four extremities are a standard question.

Direction	Site	Present location	River or setting
West	Sutkagendor	Baluchistan, Pakistan	On the Dasht , near the Makran coast
East	Alamgirpur	Uttar Pradesh, India	On the Hindon , a Yamuna tributary

Direction	Site	Present location	River or setting
North	Manda	Jammu region, India	On the Chenab
South	Daimabad	Maharashtra, India	On the Godavari

The four boundary sites

Daimabad is the one candidates get wrong, because it is also the Chalcolithic Jorwe site with the bronze chariot. **It is both, and that dual identity is itself examinable.**

JARGON DECODER · WORDS YOU NEED BEFORE THE SITE TABLE

- 1 **Citadel** - the raised, usually walled, western part of a Harappan city, carrying the large public structures. Sometimes called the **acropolis**
- 2 **Lower town** - the larger, lower eastern part, residential, laid out in a grid
- 3 **Mound** - a site is normally a low hill built from the debris of successive occupations; "two-mound site" means citadel and lower town as separate elevations
- 4 **Steatite** - soft soapstone, the material of most Harappan seals: soft enough to carve, hardened by firing
- 5 **Faience** - an artificial glazed paste used for beads and small objects; a Harappan speciality
- 6 **Terracotta** - baked clay, used for figurines, toys, bangles and pots
- 7 **Inhumation** - burial of the body in the ground, as against cremation; the normal Harappan practice

3.2 The sites - name paired with what it is famous for

This is the highest-yield table in the chapter. Almost every Harappan question in an objective paper is a site-to-find pairing - the "sites" slot of the template, and nearly the whole of the marks for this period.

Site	Location and river	What it is known for
Harappa	Punjab, Pakistan; on the Ravi	First site excavated, 1921, Daya Ram Sahni . Granaries in a double row of six; workmen's quarters ; Cemetery H and the R-37 cemetery ; the red sandstone male torso and a grey stone dancing figure
Mohenjo-daro	Sindh, Pakistan; on the Indus	The Great Bath , the most famous Harappan public structure; the Great Granary , the largest single building at the site; a pillared assembly hall ; the bronze Dancing Girl ; the steatite bearded man , often called the priest-king; the Pashupati seal
Dholavira	Gujarat (Kutch); Khadir Bet in the Rann	The only three-part Harappan city - citadel, middle town, lower town. Remarkable water reservoirs and rainwater harvesting. A large inscribed signboard of about ten signs. UNESCO World Heritage Site, inscribed 2021
Lothal	Gujarat; on the Bhogava	The dockyard - a large brick basin, generally read as a tidal dock and so among the earliest known. Bead-making factory ; fire altars ; rice husk . Excavated by S. R. Rao
Kalibangan	Rajasthan; on the dry Ghaggar	Earliest ploughed field yet found in the subcontinent. Fire altars in a row. A two-mound site. Camel bones . Discovered by A. Ghosh , excavated by B. B. Lal
Rakhigarhi	Haryana (Hisar); Ghaggar plain	The largest Harappan site in India , and on some measures the largest anywhere. Its cemetery produced the ancient-DNA study widely reported in 2019

Site	Location and river	What it is known for
Chanhudaro	Sindh, Pakistan; on the Indus	A craft town - bead-making , and the only known Harappan bangle factory . Notable for having no citadel or fortification . An inkpot , and a brick with a dog's paw print
Banawali	Haryana (Fatehabad)	Radial rather than strictly grid streets - the exception showing grid planning was a choice. Good barley ; a terracotta toy plough
Surkotada	Gujarat (Kutch)	The horse-bone claim - the most contested find in Harappan archaeology, to be stated as contested. Pot burials
Kot Diji	Sindh, Pakistan	A pre-Harappan / Early Harappan fortified settlement, giving its name to the Kot Dijian phase preceding the mature cities
Shortughai	Afghanistan, on the Oxus	A far-northern trading outpost , placed for the lapis lazuli of Badakshan - evidence that Harappan trade ran on deliberate colonies
Ganweriwala	Cholistan, Pakistan	The large, largely unexcavated site usually listed among the five biggest. Appears mainly as a distractor

Harappan sites: the pairing to learn for each

COMMON UPSC TRAP · THE FOUR SITE PAIRINGS MOST OFTEN SWAPPED IN OPTION SETS

- 1 **Great Bath at MOHENJO-DARO, not Harappa.** Harappa's signature is its **granaries**
- 2 **Dockyard at LOTHAL, not Dholavira.** Dholavira's water feature is **reservoirs** - storage, not shipping
- 3 **Ploughed field at KALIBANGAN, not Banawali.** Banawali's plough is a **terracotta toy**; Kalibangan's is an actual **field surface with furrows**
- 4 **The Dancing Girl is BRONZE and from Mohenjo-daro. The dancing figure from HARAPPA is grey stone, and Harappa's male torso is red sandstone.** Three objects, two sites, three materials

And the excavator pairing, asked directly: Sahni-Harappa-1921 and Banerji-Mohenjo-daro-1922, both under Marshall; then B. B. Lal at Kalibangan and S. R. Rao at Lothal.

MUST MASTER · TOWN PLANNING - THE FEATURE THAT DEFINES THE CIVILISATION

If a question asks what is most characteristic of the Harappans, the answer is **town planning and drainage**, not art or trade.

- 1 **Grid layout** - streets running north-south and east-west, crossing at right angles, dividing the town into rectangular blocks
- 2 **Two-part division** - a raised, generally walled **citadel** to the west carrying the public buildings; a larger residential **lower town** to the east
- 3 **Burnt brick** as the standard material - unusual in a Bronze Age where sun-dried mud brick was the norm. **Mesopotamian cities used mud brick; Harappan cities used kiln-fired brick, including in drains and bathrooms**
- 4 **Standard brick ratio 4:2:1** - length twice the width, width twice the thickness - held across the whole civilisation
- 5 **Covered underground drainage** linking individual houses to street drains, with **manholes** for cleaning and **soak pits** for solids. **No other Bronze Age civilisation had anything comparable**
- 6 **House form** - rooms around a central courtyard, doors opening onto side lanes rather than the main street, many houses with a private well or bathroom, staircases implying an upper storey
- 7 **The true arch was NOT known.** Openings use the **corbelled** arch, with courses stepped inward - a real limit on what they could span

What is conspicuously ABSENT, and this is a favourite "not correct" target: no identified temple, no identified palace, no royal burial loaded with wealth, no monumental sculpture on the Egyptian or Mesopotamian scale, no iron, and no horse-drawn chariot.

The absence is the interpretive point. In Egypt and Mesopotamia the biggest buildings are temples and palaces and the richest burials are royal. **In Harappan cities the biggest buildings are a bath, a granary and a warehouse - civic and economic, not royal or sacred.** That is why the nature of Harappan authority remains genuinely unknown, and why any confident claim about Harappan kings should be treated as suspect.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 3

- 1 Give the five tests of a civilisation, and the Harappan signature among them
- 2 Who excavated Harappa and Mohenjo-daro, in which years, under whom?
- 3 State both chronological conventions, and the formulation safe on either
- 4 Name the four boundary sites with their directions and rivers
- 5 Pair the Great Bath, the dockyard, the ploughed field and the granaries with their sites
- 6 Which site is three-part, and which has radial streets?
- 7 Give the brick ratio, and name the drainage features
- 8 Name four things absent from Harappan cities, and say what the absence implies

4. Session 4 - The Harappans II: Economy, Script, Religion, Decline ★★★★★

A trading state with standardised weights, a script nobody can read, and an ending four theories compete to explain.

MUST MASTER · AGRICULTURE, ANIMALS, CRAFTS AND WEIGHTS

- 1 **Crops** - **wheat and barley** were the staples, with peas, sesame, mustard, dates and melon. **Rice** appears at **Lothal and Rangpur** in Gujarat, not in the core Indus sites
- 2 **Cotton** - the Harappans are **the first people known to have cultivated cotton**. The Greeks later called cotton **Sindon**, from Sindh - a direct linguistic memory
- 3 **Animals kept** - the **humped bull** (the most represented of all), buffalo, sheep, goat, pig, dog, cat, the **camel** at Kalibangan, and the elephant
- 4 **Animals known but not kept**, appearing on seals - **tiger, rhinoceros, crocodile**. **The lion is absent** from Harappan representation while the tiger is present, and this has been asked
- 5 **The horse is NOT established**. The Surkotada bones are disputed and no seal depicts a horse. **State it as contested**
- 6 **Metals** - **copper** and **bronze** (copper alloyed with tin), plus gold, silver and lead. **No iron**. Copper came largely from **Khetri** in Rajasthan; bronzes were cast by the **lost-wax** process
- 7 **Crafts** - **bead-making** in carnelian, agate, steatite and faience at **Chanhudaro and Lothal**; shell-working; wheel-made pottery, characteristically **red ware with black painted designs**; seal-cutting in steatite
- 8 **Weights** - standardised in **binary** steps for the small ones (**1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64**), then **decimal multiples of 16** for the large (160, 320, 640). **Cubical**, usually of **chert**, and unmarked. Linear scales in shell and bronze come from Lothal and Mohenjo-daro

KNOW · TRADE - AND THE MECHANISM THAT WORKED WITHOUT MONEY

Mesopotamian records name trade with **Meluhha**, generally identified with the Harappan region; with **Dilmun**, identified with **Bahrain**; and with **Magan**, identified with **Oman**. **Harappan seals have been found in Mesopotamia and Mesopotamian-style cylinder seals in Harappan contexts** - the trade is attested from both ends, which makes it one of the securest facts about the civilisation. **Shortughai** in Afghanistan was an outpost placed for **lapis lazuli**.

And the qualification that makes this examinable rather than decorative: the trade was in raw materials and craft goods, and it was conducted entirely without coinage. There were no coins anywhere in the Harappan world. **Weights plus seals plus barter is the mechanism** - the seal identifying the consignor, the weight settling the quantity. **Any option asserting Harappan coinage is false**, and it appears regularly.

4.1 The seals and the script

Feature	The position
Material and form	Mostly steatite , typically square with a boss on the back for a cord, carrying an animal figure plus a short line of script
Commonest animal	The one-horned animal conventionally called the unicorn , followed by the humped bull
Function	Almost certainly commercial - stamping consignments, identifying owner or merchant. Seal impressions on clay tags support this
The Pashupati seal	From Mohenjo-daro . A seated figure with a horned headdress, surrounded by animals, in what looks like a yogic posture. Marshall read it as a proto-Shiva or Pashupati , lord of beasts. This is an interpretation, not a fact , and should be stated that way
Script direction	Generally right to left ; where a line runs on, boustrophedon - alternate lines reversing, like a plough turning at the end of a furrow
Number of signs	Of the order of 375 to 400 distinct signs - far too many for an alphabet, too few for a purely pictographic system, hence the usual description logo-syllabic
Decipherment	Undeciphered . Inscriptions are very short, averaging about five signs; there is no bilingual text of the kind that unlocked Egyptian, and the underlying language is unknown. Treat every claimed decipherment as unproven

The seals and the script: what is known, and what is not

Why the non-decipherment governs everything else. We can read Ashoka because Prinsep cracked Brahmi, and can therefore name Mauryan officials, taxes and policies. **We cannot read a single Harappan word, so we do not know what the Harappans called themselves, who ruled them, what they believed, or what language they spoke.** Everything below is inference from objects - **which is precisely why a "not correct" question about Harappan religion or kingship is answerable: the confidently specific option is usually the false one.**

KNOW · RELIGION AND BURIAL - INFERENCE FROM OBJECTS, LABELLED AS INFERENCE

- 1 **Mother Goddess figurines** - numerous terracotta female figures, generally read as a fertility or mother-goddess cult
- 2 **The Pashupati seal** - the possible proto-Shiva, as above
- 3 **Tree and animal veneration** - the **pipal** recurs on seals, as does the humped bull
- 4 Stone objects read as **lingam and yoni** by Marshall, suggesting a phallic cult. **This reading is contested**
- 5 **Fire altars** in rows at **Kalibangan**, and also at **Lothal** and **Banawali** - suggesting fire ritual without proving it
- 6 **The Great Bath** is generally taken to indicate **ritual bathing**, which would be a striking continuity with later Indian practice
- 7 **No temples, no large cult statues, no priestly iconography** of the Egyptian or Mesopotamian kind

Burial practice, which is harder evidence than any of the above. The normal method was **inhumation**, the body extended in a pit usually **north-south**, with pottery and sometimes ornaments. **Lothal** produced apparent **double burials**; **Kalibangan** produced **symbolic burials**, with grave goods and no body; **Surkotada** produced **pot burials**. **No royal burial loaded with wealth has been found anywhere** - the same absence as in Session 3, and the strongest single argument against reading the Harappans as a conventional monarchy.

KNOW · ART - THE FIVE OBJECTS WORTH RECOGNISING BY NAME

Harappan art is small in scale; there is no monumental sculpture. Five objects carry nearly all the questions.

- 1 **The Dancing Girl** - **bronze**, from **Mohenjo-daro**, cast by the **lost-wax** process
- 2 **The bearded man** - **steatite**, from **Mohenjo-daro**, often labelled the **priest-king**. The label is a guess and the paper sometimes tests exactly that, so prefer "bearded man"
- 3 **The red sandstone male torso** - from **Harappa**, anatomically modelled well beyond what the period elsewhere achieved
- 4 **The grey stone dancing figure** - also from **Harappa**, and distinct from the bronze Dancing Girl
- 5 **The Daimabad bronzes** - a **chariot** drawn by oxen, plus rhinoceros, elephant and buffalo. **Daimabad is Late Harappan and Chalcolithic**, so these are late

Beyond those five, terracotta everywhere - figurines, animal toys including a bull with a movable head and a monkey on a string, whistles, carts, bangles. **Terracotta is the characteristic Harappan medium, and the toys are legitimate evidence of a prosperous urban society with leisure and children's goods.**

4.2 Decline - four theories, none decisive

The mature phase ends around **1900 BCE**, and the ending is a **de-urbanisation** rather than an extinction: cities shrink or are abandoned, the script and the weights and the long-distance trade disappear, and the population continues in smaller Late Harappan village settlements. **Learn the theories with their proponents, because the standard question asks who argued what.**

Theory	Associated with	The argument, and its weakness
Aryan invasion	Mortimer Wheeler	Skeletons at Mohenjo-daro read as massacre victims, plus Rig Vedic references to destroying fortified places. Now largely rejected - the skeletons are of different periods and show no battle pattern, and the dates do not align
Flooding and river change	Marshall; S. R. Rao	Repeated Indus flooding and silt deposits at Mohenjo-daro. Explains individual sites, not a civilisation-wide collapse
Climate change and aridity	Wide modern support	Progressive drying, a weakening monsoon, and above all the drying of the Ghaggar-Hakra system on which a very large number of sites sat. The explanation with the widest current support , and it fits the geography of abandonment
Tectonic disturbance	Robert Raikes	Earthquake-driven uplift damming the river, drowning or stranding settlements. Local rather than general
Collapse of trade	-	The fall of the Mesopotamian market removed the demand Harappan craft production served. Contributory rather than sufficient

Theories of Harappan decline

BEGINNER MISTAKE · THE THREE ERRORS TO STOP MAKING ABOUT THE DECLINE

- 1 **Do not say the Harappans "disappeared".** They **de-urbanised**. Late Harappan village cultures continue for centuries and elements of material culture persist. **Continuity, not extinction, is the current reading**
- 2 **Do not present the Aryan invasion as the accepted cause.** It is the **historically famous** theory and the **currently rejected** one. Asked who propounded it, the answer is **Wheeler**; asked what is now accepted, the answer is **climatic and hydrological change**. **Two different questions with two different answers, and candidates routinely give one when asked the other**
- 3 **Do not offer a single cause in an interview.** The defensible position is that **environmental change, above all the Ghaggar-Hakra drying, combined with the loss of external trade** removed the basis for large urban settlement - **multi-causal, with aridity dominant**

Why this matters beyond the marks. The Harappan decline is the first case in Indian history of an administrative and economic system failing because its **resource base** shifted rather than because it was defeated - a recognisable modern problem, and a legitimate thing to say if an interview turns to institutional resilience.

ACTION · WHERE THIS LEAVES YOU, AND WHAT F5.2 DOES

You now hold the method for the whole module - the five-slot template, the recognition principle, the stopping rule, and the day 1 / day 7 / day 30 wall-sheet schedule - plus the sources of ancient Indian history, the prehistoric sequence, and the Harappan civilisation in full.

Check that the method landed, not just the facts. If you finished this chapter having read every word twice, you have already made the mistake it was written to prevent. **One careful pass, then the wall sheet at day 1, day 7 and day 30.**

F5.2 takes the Vedic Age - early and later - where the evidence reverses completely: the Harappans left things and no readable words, the Vedic people left words and almost no things. It then carries you to the **mahajanapadas** and the **second urbanisation** of the sixth century BCE, which is the doorway to F5.3 on Buddhism, Jainism and the reform movements.

5. Graded Practice - 42 Questions ★★★★★

5.1 Level 1 - Recognition

Q. 1. Harappa was excavated in 1921 by

(a) Daya Ram Sahni (b) R. D. Banerji (c) John Marshall (d) B. B. Lal

Q. 2. Mohenjo-daro is situated on the bank of the

(a) Ravi (b) Indus (c) Ghaggar (d) Chenab

Q. 3. Harappa is situated on the bank of the

(a) Bhogava (b) Indus (c) Ravi (d) Hindon

Q. 4. The Brahmi script was deciphered in 1837 by

(a) Robert Bruce Foote (b) Mortimer Wheeler (c) John Marshall (d) James Prinsep

Q. 5. Bhimbetka is known for

(a) rock paintings (b) pit dwellings (c) ash mounds (d) a dockyard

Q. 6. The earliest farming settlement in the subcontinent, with the earliest evidence of cotton, is

(a) Burzahom (b) Mehrgarh (c) Chirand (d) Bagor

Q. 7. Pit dwellings, and dogs buried with their masters, are associated with

(a) Adamgarh (b) Koldihwa (c) Burzahom (d) Inamgaon

Q. 8. Microliths are the distinctive tool type of the

(a) Palaeolithic (b) Chalcolithic (c) Neolithic (d) Mesolithic

Q. 9. The Great Bath is at

(a) Mohenjo-daro (b) Lothal (c) Harappa (d) Dholavira

Q. 10. The dockyard is at

(a) Dholavira (b) Lothal (c) Surkotada (d) Chanhudaro

Q. 11. The earliest ploughed field found in the subcontinent is at

(a) Banawali (b) Rakhigarhi (c) Kalibangan (d) Alamgirpur

Q. 12. The largest Harappan site in India is

(a) Lothal (b) Dholavira (c) Kalibangan (d) Rakhigarhi

Q. 13. The standard ratio of Harappan bricks was

(a) 4:2:1 (b) 3:2:1 (c) 2:1:1 (d) 5:3:1

Q. 14. The Dancing Girl from Mohenjo-daro is made of

(a) red sandstone (b) bronze (c) steatite (d) terracotta

Q. 15. The metal NOT known to the Harappans was

(a) copper (b) bronze (c) iron (d) silver

Q. 16. The metal whose first use defines the Chalcolithic period is

(a) iron (b) lead (c) tin (d) copper

5.2 Level 2 - Understanding

Q. 17. An inscription is generally treated as a more reliable source than a literary text because

(a) inscriptions are contemporary with the event and, being cut in stone or metal, cannot be altered by later copyists (b) inscriptions are always longer (c) literary texts are always religious (d) inscriptions were written by trained historians

Q. 18. Fa-Hien visited India during the reign of

(a) Chandragupta Maurya (b) Chandragupta II (c) Ashoka (d) Harshavardhana

Q. 19. Al-Biruni, author of Kitab-ul-Hind, came to India with

(a) Alexander (b) Muhammad Ghori (c) Mahmud of Ghazni (d) Babur

Q. 20. The only Harappan city divided into three parts - citadel, middle town and lower town - is

(a) Mohenjo-daro (b) Harappa (c) Lothal (d) Dholavira

Q. 21. Chanhudaro is distinctive among major Harappan sites because it

(a) had no citadel or fortification, and was a craft town for bead and bangle making (b) had the largest granary (c) was the northernmost site (d) yielded the Pashupati seal

Q. 22. The Harappan system of weights proceeded in

(a) decimal steps throughout (b) binary steps 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64 for the smaller weights, then decimal multiples of 16 for the larger (c) multiples of 12 (d) no discernible system

Q. 23. In Mesopotamian records, Meluhha is generally identified with

(a) Bahrain (b) Oman (c) the Harappan region (d) Egypt

Q. 24. The Harappan script is generally written

(a) left to right throughout (b) in a spiral (c) vertically (d) right to left, with alternate lines reversing direction where a text runs on

Q. 25. The correct statement about the Pashupati seal is that

(a) the identification with a proto-Shiva is Marshall's interpretation and remains an interpretation, not an established fact (b) it proves the Harappans worshipped Shiva (c) it was found at Harappa (d) it carries a deciphered inscription naming the deity

Q. 26. The explanation of Harappan decline with the widest current support is

(a) an Aryan invasion (b) climatic and hydrological change, above all the drying of the Ghaggar-Hakra system (c) an epidemic (d) tectonic uplift alone

Q. 27. The Aryan invasion theory of Harappan decline is associated with

(a) John Marshall (b) Robert Raikes (c) Mortimer Wheeler (d) S. R. Rao

Q. 28. The Harappans are the first people known to have cultivated

(a) rice (b) tea (c) sugarcane (d) cotton

Q. 29. Harappan openings and drains were spanned using

(a) the corbelled arch, the true arch being unknown to them (b) the true arch (c) iron lintels (d) timber vaults only

Q. 30. In present-day Afghanistan, Ashoka's inscriptions were engraved in

- (a) Brahmi only (b) Greek and Aramaic (c) Kharosthi only (d) Tamil

5.3 Level 3 - Recruitment Test standard

Q. 31. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Site)	List-II (Find)
A. Lothal	1. Earliest ploughed field with furrows
B. Dholavira	2. Dockyard
C. Kalibangan	3. Bangle factory, and no fortification
D. Chanhudaro	4. Three-part town with large water reservoirs

- (a) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3 (b) A-4 B-2 C-3 D-1 (c) A-2 B-4 C-1 D-3 (d) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2

Q. 32. Which one of the following statements about the Harappan civilisation is NOT correct?

- (a) Bricks were kiln-fired and made to a standard 4:2:1 ratio (b) Covered underground drains connected individual houses to street drains (c) No structure has been securely identified as a temple (d) Iron was used for tools and weapons

Q. 33. Arrange the following in correct chronological order, earliest first: 1. Farming at Mehrgarh · 2. Mature Harappan town planning · 3. Microlithic tool industries · 4. Late Harappan de-urbanisation

- (a) 3-1-2-4 (b) 1-3-2-4 (c) 3-2-1-4 (d) 1-2-3-4

Q. 34. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Visitor)	List-II (Contemporary ruler)
A. Fa-Hien	1. Harshavardhana
B. Hiuen Tsang	2. Chandragupta Maurya
C. Al-Biruni	3. Chandragupta II
D. Megasthenes	4. Mahmud of Ghazni

- (a) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (b) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-1 C-2 D-4 (d) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3

Q. 35. Consider the following statements about the Harappan civilisation: 1. No structure has been securely identified as a temple. · 2. No royal burial with conspicuous wealth has been found. · 3. Monumental stone sculpture on the Egyptian scale is absent. Which are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 1, 2 and 3 (d) 2 and 3 only

Q. 36. Which one of the following statements about Harappan town planning is NOT correct?

- (a) Streets crossed one another at right angles in a grid (b) Houses were built around a central courtyard, opening onto side lanes (c) Drains were covered and provided with manholes and soak pits (d) The true arch was widely used in gateways and drains

Q. 37. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Boundary site)	List-II (Extremity)
A. Sutkagendor	1. Northern
B. Alamgirpur	2. Eastern
C. Manda	3. Southern
D. Daimabad	4. Western

(a) A-4 B-2 C-1 D-3 (b) A-1 B-2 C-4 D-3 (c) A-4 B-3 C-1 D-2 (d) A-2 B-4 C-3 D-1

Q. 38. Which one of the following combinations of art object, material and site is correctly matched?

(a) Dancing Girl - red sandstone - Harappa (b) Bearded man - steatite - Mohenjo-daro (c) Male torso - bronze - Mohenjo-daro (d) Chariot figure - steatite - Kalibangan

Q. 39. The reason the nature of Harappan political authority remains genuinely unknown is best stated as

(a) no excavation has been carried out on the citadels (b) the Harappans had no political authority at all (c) the script is undeciphered, and no palace, royal burial or royal inscription has been identified anywhere in the civilisation (d) all Harappan records were written on palm leaf and have perished

Q. 40. Which one of the following statements about the Harappan economy is NOT correct?

(a) Weights were cubical and usually made of chert (b) Copper came largely from Khetri in Rajasthan (c) The Harappans were the first known cultivators of cotton (d) Coinage was in regular use for internal trade

Q. 41. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Site)	List-II (Excavator)
A. Harappa	1. R. D. Banerji
B. Mohenjo-daro	2. S. R. Rao
C. Kalibangan	3. Daya Ram Sahni
D. Lothal	4. B. B. Lal

(a) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (b) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-1 C-2 D-4 (d) A-4 B-1 C-3 D-2

Q. 42. Consider the following statements about the end of the Harappan civilisation: 1. The mature phase ends around 1900 BCE. · 2. The cities were abandoned or shrank, but Late Harappan village settlements continued for centuries. · 3. The Aryan invasion theory is currently the best-supported explanation. Which are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

6. Answers and Explanations

6.1 Level 1 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
1	a	Daya Ram Sahni , 1921. (b) Banerji excavated Mohenjo-daro in 1922 - the commonest swap in the topic. (c) Marshall was the Director-General who announced and named the civilisation but did not dig it. (d) B. B. Lal excavated Kalibangan , much later
2	b	Mohenjo-daro sits on the Indus , in Sindh. (a) Ravi is Harappa; (c) Ghaggar is Kalibangan and Rakhigarhi; (d) Chenab is Manda
3	c	Harappa is on the Ravi . (a) Bhogava is Lothal; (d) Hindon is Alamgirpur
4	d	James Prinsep , 1837 - the act that made the Mauryan period historical. (a) Foote found the first recognised Palaeolithic tool in India in 1863; (b) Wheeler propounded the Aryan invasion theory; (c) Marshall named the Indus civilisation
5	a	Bhimbetka , Madhya Pradesh - rock paintings , a UNESCO World Heritage Site. (b) pit dwellings are Burzahom; (c) ash mounds are the southern Neolithic; (d) a dockyard is Lothal
6	b	Mehrgarh , in present-day Baluchistan. (a) Burzahom is Neolithic Kashmir; (c) Chirand is Neolithic Bihar with bone tools; (d) Bagor is the largest Mesolithic site
7	c	Burzahom , Kashmir. (a) Adamgarh gives early animal domestication; (b) Koldihwa the contested earliest rice; (d) Inamgaon is a Chalcolithic Jorwe site
8	d	Microliths define the Mesolithic . (a) Palaeolithic tools are large quartzite hand-axes and cleavers; (c) the Neolithic marker is farming with polished tools; (b) the Chalcolithic marker is copper
9	a	Mohenjo-daro . (c) Harappa's signature is its granaries ; (d) Dholavira's water feature is reservoirs , which is storage rather than bathing
10	b	Lothal , Gujarat, on the Bhogava. (a) Dholavira has reservoirs; (c) Surkotada the contested horse bones and pot burials; (d) Chanhudaro the bead and bangle crafts
11	c	Kalibangan - an actual field surface with furrows in two directions. (a) Banawali's plough is a terracotta toy , which is the distractor this question is built on
12	d	Rakhigarhi , Haryana - largest Harappan site in India, and source of the widely reported 2019 ancient-DNA study
13	a	4:2:1 - length twice width, width twice thickness - held constant across the whole civilisation, and it is that standardisation which makes the Harappans a state
14	b	Bronze , by the lost-wax process. (a) Red sandstone is the male torso from Harappa ; (c) steatite is the bearded man ; (d) terracotta is the figurine and toy medium. Four materials, four different objects
15	c	Iron . The Harappans were a Bronze Age people - copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead, but no iron. "The Harappans used iron" is a standard false option
16	d	Copper , used alongside stone, which is what "Chalcolithic" means. (a) Iron defines the later Iron Age; (c) tin matters only as the alloying metal in bronze

6.2 Level 2 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
17	a	Contemporaneity plus non-alterability . A manuscript is hand-copied for centuries and can be interpolated or re-dated; stone cannot be edited after the fact. (b) is irrelevant - most inscriptions are short. (d) is false: inscriptions were cut for administrative or votive purposes, not to write history
18	b	Chandragupta II , in the Gupta period. (d) Harshavardhana is Hiuen Tsang's patron - the commonest confusion in this topic. Use F before H before A
19	c	Mahmud of Ghazni , 11th century. Kitab-ul-Hind is the fullest early Arabic account of Indian sciences and society

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
20	d	Dholavira , on Khadir Bet in the Rann of Kutch - citadel, middle town, lower town. Every other major city is two-part
21	a	No citadel or fortification , and a craft town for beads and bangles - the only known Harappan bangle factory. (b) the largest granary is at Mohenjo-daro; (d) the Pashupati seal is also Mohenjo-daro
22	b	Binary to 64, then decimal multiples of 16 - 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, then 160, 320, 640. Cubical, usually chert. (d) is exactly wrong: the regularity across a thousand kilometres is the point
23	c	Meluhha is the Harappan region. (a) Dilmun is Bahrain, (b) Magan is Oman - all three appear in the same Mesopotamian records, which is why they are offered together
24	d	Right to left , and boustrophedon where a text runs to a second line. (a) describes Brahmi, not Harappan
25	a	Interpretation, not fact. Marshall's proto-Shiva reading is plausible and widely repeated but unproven - and it cannot be confirmed, because (d) is false: the script is undeciphered. (c) is wrong on provenance; the seal is from Mohenjo-daro
26	b	Climatic and hydrological change , above all the drying of the Ghaggar-Hakra , on which very many sites sat. (a) is the famous but now largely rejected theory; (d) tectonic uplift is local rather than general
27	c	Mortimer Wheeler. Note the trap this sets with Q26: who propounded the invasion theory and what is now accepted are different questions with different answers, and candidates routinely give one when asked the other
28	d	Cotton - and the Greek word Sindon , from Sindh, is a direct linguistic memory of it. (a) Rice was cultivated but not first, and in the Harappan world appears mainly at Lothal and Rangpur
29	a	The corbelled arch , with courses stepped inward. The true arch was NOT known to the Harappans , and that is a genuine engineering limitation on what they could span - worth noticing as an engineer
30	b	Greek and Aramaic , including the bilingual edict at Kandahar. Brahmi covers the great majority of edicts elsewhere and Kharosthi the north-west, so (a) and (c) are each true of a different region but false of Afghanistan

6.3 Level 3 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
31	c	A-2 Lothal dockyard · B-4 Dholavira three-part town with reservoirs · C-1 Kalibangan ploughed field · D-3 Chanhudaro bangle factory and no fortification. Note the scoring method: knowing only Lothal-dockyard and Kalibangan-field eliminates (b), (a) and (d) without needing the other two pairs at all
32	d	(d) is the false statement. The Harappans were a Bronze Age civilisation with no iron . (a), (b) and (c) are all true, and (c) - the absence of an identified temple - is exactly the true-but-surprising statement candidates pick by mistake
33	a	3-1-2-4. Microlithic industries are Mesolithic , c. 10,000-6,000 BCE · farming at Mehrgarh from about 7000 BCE · Mature Harappan c. 2600-1900 BCE · Late Harappan de-urbanisation from c. 1900 BCE. This is the chronological spine of the chapter in one question
34	b	A-3 Fa-Hien with Chandragupta II · B-1 Hiuen Tsang with Harshavardhana · C-4 Al-Biruni with Mahmud of Ghazni · D-2 Megasthenes with Chandragupta Maurya. Option (a) swaps the two Chinese pilgrims, which is the intended trap

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
35	c	All three are correct. No identified temple, no wealthy royal burial, and no monumental stone sculpture on the Egyptian or Mesopotamian scale. The set is worth holding together, because these three absences are what make Harappan authority unreadable - and a candidate who doubts any one of them will wrongly downgrade to (b) or (d)
36	d	(d) is false. The Harappans used the corbelled arch; the true arch was unknown to them. (a), (c) and (b) are all correct descriptions of Harappan planning, and (c) - covered drains with manholes and soak pits - is the civilisation's single most distinctive feature
37	a	A-4 Sutkagendor west · B-2 Alamgirpur east · C-1 Manda north · D-3 Daimabad south. Daimabad is the one to fix , because it is both the southern Harappan extremity and the Chalcolithic Jorwe site of the bronze chariot
38	b	Bearded man - steatite - Mohenjo-daro is the correct triple. (a) is wrong twice: the Dancing Girl is bronze and from Mohenjo-daro . (c) is wrong twice: the male torso is red sandstone and from Harappa . (d) is wrong twice: the chariot is bronze and from Daimabad
39	c	The undeciphered script, plus the absence of palace, royal burial and royal inscription. (a) is false - the citadels are among the most thoroughly excavated areas. (b) overstates: standardised bricks and weights across 1.3 million square kilometres prove an authority existed. (d) invents a fact; there is no evidence of a perished palm-leaf archive
40	d	(d) is false. There was no coinage anywhere in the Harappan world. Exchange ran on seals plus standardised weights plus barter , which is why the weights are so uniform. (a), (b) and (c) are all true, and any option asserting Harappan coins should be eliminated on sight
41	a	A-3 Harappa-Daya Ram Sahni · B-1 Mohenjo-daro-R. D. Banerji · C-4 Kalibangan-B. B. Lal · D-2 Lothal-S. R. Rao. Fixing only the first two pairs eliminates (b), (c) and (d) - the same partial-knowledge method as Q31
42	b	1 and 2 only. The mature phase ends about 1900 BCE and Late Harappan villages continue for centuries - de-urbanisation, not disappearance. Statement 3 is false: the Aryan invasion theory is the historically famous explanation and the currently rejected one; the best-supported explanation is climatic and hydrological, above all the drying of the Ghaggar-Hakra

7. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F5.1 - METHOD, SOURCES, PREHISTORY, THE HARAPPANS

METHOD objective papers test **RECOGNITION not RECALL** · so in history **one exposure to a wide field beats five to a narrow one** - the reverse of Polity · five-slot template per period: **SITES ·**

RULERS · TEXTS · MONUMENTS · DISTINCTIVE FEATURE · when the five slots are full the period is FINISHED · revise from the **wall sheet at day 1, day 7, day 30**, never by re-reading · four chronological anchors: **Harappan cities, the Buddha, Ashoka, the Guptas** · in matching questions **two confident pairs usually eliminate three codes**

2023 EVIDENCE history gave **10 questions**, of which **NINE were ancient, medieval or art-and-culture** · 2025 was closer to half modern · front-load ancient and cultural, do not abandon modern

SOURCES epigraphy = inscriptions · numismatics = coins · inscription beats text because contemporary and unalterable · **JAMES PRINSEP DECIPHERED BRAHMI IN 1837** - the hinge of ancient Indian history; before him nobody knew Devanampiya Piyadasi was Ashoka · Ashokan scripts **Brahmi** (most, left-to-right), **Kharosthi** (north-west, right-to-left), **Greek and Aramaic** (Afghanistan, bilingual edict at Kandahar) · earliest coins **punch-marked / karshapana** · first portrait coins **Indo-Greeks** · most gold coins **Guptas**

TRAVELLER PAIRS **Fa-Hien-Chandragupta II · Hiuen Tsang-Harshavardhana · Al-Biruni-Mahmud of Ghazni · Megasthenes-Chandragupta Maurya** · F before H before A and the patrons follow in time

TEXT-AUTHOR PAIRS Arthashastra-**Kautilya** · Indica-**Megasthenes** · Mudrarakshasa-**Vishakhadatta** · Rajatarangini-**Kalhana** · Ashtadhyayi-**Panini** · Mahabhashya-**Patanjali** · Kitab-ul-Hind-**Al-Biruni** · Periplus = Indo-Roman trade

PREHISTORY Bhimbetka = **ROCK PAINTINGS** (UNESCO) · **Robert Bruce Foote, Pallavaram, 1863** = first Palaeolithic tool found in India · **Bagor** largest Mesolithic · **Adamgarh + Bagor** earliest animal domestication · **MICROLITHS = MESOLITHIC** · **Mehrgarh = earliest farming + earliest cotton** · **Burzahom = pit dwellings + dog burials** · **Chirand = bone tools** · **Koldihwa = contested earliest rice** · **COPPER = CHALCOLITHIC**, cultures Ahar-Banas, Kayatha, Malwa, **Jorwe**, pottery **Black-and-Red Ware** · surplus → non-farming specialists → cities, writing, the state **HARAPPA - DISCOVERY AND DATES** Harappa 1921 **DAYA RAM SAHNI** · Mohenjo-daro 1922 **R. D. BANERJI** · both under **JOHN MARSHALL**, who named it · Kalibangan **B. B. Lal**, Lothal **S. R. Rao** · Mohenjo-daro = "mound of the dead" · current convention **Early 3300-2600 · Mature 2600-1900 · Late 1900-1300 BCE**; older convention **2500-1750** · safe on both: "**second half of the third millennium BCE**" · **BRONZE AGE, NO IRON** · contemporary with Mesopotamia and Egypt **HARAPPA - EXTENT** about **1.3 million sq km**, largest Bronze Age civilisation by area · **W Sutkagendor** (Dasht) · **E Alamgirpur** (Hindon) · **N Manda** (Chenab) · **S Daimabad** (Godavari, and also the Jorwe bronze-chariot site)

HARAPPA - SITES Mohenjo-daro Great Bath, Great Granary, pillared hall, bronze Dancing Girl, steatite bearded man, Pashupati seal · **Harappa** granaries in a double row of six, workmen's quarters, Cemetery H and R-37, red sandstone torso, grey stone dancing figure · **Dholavira** three-part town, reservoirs, ten-sign signboard, UNESCO 2021 · **Lothal** dockyard, bead factory, fire altars, rice husk · **Kalibangan** ploughed field, fire altars, camel bones · **Rakhigarhi** largest in India, 2019 DNA study · **Chanhudaro** bangle factory, NO fortification, inkpot, dog paw print · **Banawali** radial streets, toy plough · **Surkotada** contested horse bones, pot burials · **Kot Diji** Early Harappan fortified · **Shortughai** Afghan lapis-lazuli outpost

HARAPPA - PLANNING grid at right angles · citadel west + lower town east · **kiln-fired burnt brick** where Mesopotamia used mud brick · ratio **4:2:1** · **COVERED DRAINS with manholes and soak pits - the signature** · courtyard houses opening on side lanes · **CORBELLED arch, TRUE ARCH NOT KNOWN · ABSENT: temple, palace, royal burial, monumental sculpture, iron, horse chariot** - biggest buildings are a bath, a granary and a warehouse, so authority is civic-looking and unreadable

HARAPPA - ECONOMY wheat and barley staples, rice only Lothal and Rangpur · **FIRST CULTIVATORS OF COTTON**, Greek **Sindon** from Sindh · **humped bull** most represented, camel at Kalibangan, **tiger yes / lion no** · **horse NOT established** (Surkotada contested) · copper from **Khetri**, bronzes by **lost wax** · weights **binary to 64 then decimal multiples of 16**, cubical chert · **NO COINAGE** - seals + weights + barter · **Meluhha = Harappan, Dilmun = Bahrain, Magan = Oman**, attested from both ends

HARAPPA - SEALS, SCRIPT, RELIGION, ART steatite squares, animal plus script, commonest the **one-horned "unicorn"** then the humped bull, function **commercial** · **Pashupati seal = Marshall's INTERPRETATION** · script **right to left, boustrophedon, ~375-400 signs, logo-syllabic, UNDECIPHERED**, no bilingual key · Mother Goddess terracottas, pipal and bull veneration, lingam-yoni reading contested, **fire altars at Kalibangan, Lothal, Banawali**, Great Bath read as ritual bathing · burials **extended inhumation N-S, double at Lothal, symbolic at Kalibangan, pot at Surkotada** · five art objects **bronze Dancing Girl** and **steatite bearded man** (Mohenjo-daro), **red sandstone torso** and **grey stone dancing figure** (Harappa), **Daimabad bronzes**

HARAPPA - DECLINE **Wheeler** Aryan invasion (famous, now rejected) · **Marshall and S. R. Rao** flooding · **Raikes** tectonic · **climate and the drying GHAGGAR-HAKRA = widest current support** · collapse of Mesopotamian trade contributory · **it is DE-URBANISATION, NOT DISAPPEARANCE** - **Late Harappan villages continue** · in an interview give it as **multi-causal with aridity dominant**, and note that this is the first Indian case of a system failing because its resource base shifted rather than because it was defeated

8. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F5.1 - HISTORY METHOD AND THE HARAPPANS

METHOD: RECOGNITION not RECALL · wide beats deep · SITES RULERS TEXTS MONUMENTS FEATURE

Wall sheet at day 1, day 7, day 30 · TEST, never re-read

2023: 10 history Q, NINE ancient/medieval/culture

Epigraphy = inscriptions · Numismatics = coins · inscription beats text

JAMES PRINSEP deciphered BRAHMI in 1837

Ashoka: Brahmi (most) · Kharosthi (NW) · GREEK + ARAMAIC (Afghanistan)

Fa-Hien = Chandragupta II · Hiuen Tsang = Harsha · Al-Biruni = Mahmud of Ghazni ·

Megasthenes = Chandragupta Maurya

Arthashastra-Kautilya · Rajatarangini-Kalhana · Ashtadhyayi-Panini ·

Mudrarakshasa-Vishakhadatta

Bhimbetka = ROCK PAINTINGS · Mehrgarh = FARMING + COTTON · Burzahom = PIT DWELLINGS + DOG BURIALS

MICROLITHS = MESOLITHIC · COPPER = CHALCOLITHIC · Bagor = largest Mesolithic ·

Chirand = bone tools

Harappa 1921 SAHNI · Mohenjo-daro 1922 BANERJI · both under MARSHALL · Kalibangan B. B. LAL · Lothal S. R. RAO

Mature Harappan 2600-1900 BCE (older convention 2500-1750) · BRONZE AGE, NO IRON · 1.3 million sq km

Boundaries: W SUTKAGENDOR · E ALAMGIRPUR · N MANDA · S DAIMABAD

GREAT BATH = Mohenjo-daro · GRANARIES = Harappa · DOCKYARD = Lothal · RESERVOIRS + 3 PARTS = Dholavira

PLOUGHED FIELD = Kalibangan · TOY PLOUGH + RADIAL STREETS = Banawali · LARGEST IN INDIA = Rakhigarhi

BANGLE FACTORY + NO FORT = Chanhudaro · HORSE BONES (contested) = Surkotada ·

LAPIS OUTPOST = Shortughai

Brick ratio 4:2:1 · kiln-fired · COVERED DRAINS = the signature · CORBELLED arch, NO true arch

ABSENT: temple, palace, royal burial, monumental sculpture, iron, horse chariot

Wheat + barley staples · rice only Lothal/Rangpur · FIRST COTTON (Greek "Sindon")

Weights BINARY to 64, then decimal $\times 16$ · cubical chert · NO COINS - seals + weights + barter

Meluhha = Harappan · Dilmun = BAHRAIN · Magan = OMAN

Script RIGHT TO LEFT, boustrophedon, ~375-400 signs, UNDECIPHERED

Pashupati seal = Marshall's INTERPRETATION, not fact

Dancing Girl BRONZE Mohenjo-daro · bearded man STEATITE Mohenjo-daro · torso RED SANDSTONE Harappa

Fire altars: KALIBANGAN, LOTHAL, BANAWALI · burials: double LOTHAL, symbolic KALIBANGAN, pot SURKOTADA

Decline: WHEELER invasion (REJECTED) · GHAGGAR-HAKRA DRYING best supported ·

DE-URBANISATION not disappearance, and Late Harappan villages continue for centuries